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MULTIPLE TRANSLATIONS OF GIACOMO LEOPARDI'S "L'INFINITO"

By Giuseppe Natale

L'Infinito

Sempre caro mi fu quest'ermo colle*,
E questa siepe, che da tanta parte
Dell'ultimo orizzonte il guardo esclude*.
4 **Ma** sedendo e mirando, interminati
Spazi di là da quella, e sovrumani
Silenzi, e profondissima quiete
Io nel pensier mi fingo*; **ov**e per poco
8 Il cor non si spaura. **E come** il vento
Odo stormir* tra queste piante, io quello
Infinito silenzio a questa voce
Vo comparando*: e mi sovvien l'eterno,
12 **E** le morte stagioni, e la presente
E viva, e il suon di lei. **Così** tra questa
Immensità annega il pensier mio*:
E il naufragar m'è dolce* in questo mare.

Giacomo Leopardi (1819)¹

George Steiner, in *After Babel*,² outlines a process of reading that develops like a double spiral: departing from the text, it moves externally toward literature at large and internally toward the author's mind. This dual hermeneutic motion is particularly suitable to *L'Infinito* because of the intrinsic dual nature of the poem itself: *L'Infinito* is at the same time a poetic creation and a reflection on poetic creation. On the one hand, a textual study that develops externally can enable the translator to identify the syntactical, lexical, and phonetic elements of this finely engineered poem and to place it meaningfully in the literary framework that generated it. On the other hand, a textual study that develops internally toward the author's mind, toward the referential framework in which the act of creating *L'Infinito* took place, can indirectly shed some light on the mechanics of creation described in the poem.

L'Infinito belongs to the first series of idylls that Giacomo Leopardi composed between 1819 and 1821, and that were later included in his collection of poems titled *Canti* (1831). Leopardi defined his idylls as *canti* that portray situazioni, affezioni, avventure storiche: idylls take form when a place permeated with old mem-

ories stirs certain sensations in the poet's mind. The description that Leopardi gives of idyll deviates substantially from its accepted definition in the ancient and classical tradition. In ancient times, *eidullion*, the diminutive of the Greek term *eidos*, broadly referred to a short lyric, in contrast with the lengthier *eide*, used to describe grand lyrical poems like the Pindaric odes. In the classical tradition, the acceptance of the term changed. Idyll now indicated a short poem evoking the serene atmosphere of country life, as ideally opposed to the disorderly city life. In its later evolution, during the Renaissance, idyllic poetry ceased to be a separate literary entity and flowed into the greater body of bucolic poetry. The term idyllic thus came to describe mainly the tone of an artistic creation rather than a category of composition. By the 19th century, when *L'Infinito* was composed, idyll as a lyric form had undergone a further change, brought about by the Romantic revolution. Idyllic poetry now did not simply refer to the contemplation of a tranquil scene or episode of rustic life but also entailed the emotional participation of the poet. In the Romantic idyll, the poet's musings did not necessarily resolve into the bucolic and the picturesque but could be instead the prelude to the narration of a tragic theme.

Margaret Brose, in her essay "Leopardi and the Romantic sublime," links *L'Infinito* to the greater Romantic lyric, as that form, identified by Abrams, that replaced the greater ode, the elevated Pindaric. The idyll, says Abrams, usually depicts a determinate speaker in a particularized outdoor setting, who carries on a soliloquy with himself or the outer scene, or an absent or silent human auditor. The speaker begins with a description of the landscape; ...an aspect in the landscape evokes a varied but integral process of memory, thought, anticipation, and feeling ...In the course of this meditation the lyric speaker achieves an insight, faces up to a tragic loss, comes to a moral decision, or resolves an emotional problem.³

According to Abrams' tripartite scheme, Romantic idylls are built on the interplay of the poet's mind and nature, on a repeated out-in-out process. In Leopardi's poem, this process finds expression in the dichotomous opposition of definite and indefinite, where the former represents reality and the latter the

poet's imagination. This interpretation finds a direct confirmation in a comment by Leopardi recorded in his *Zibaldone*, two years after he composed the idyll:

In regard to the sensations which are pleasing by virtue of the indefinite alone, see my idyll on *L'Infinito*, and picture to yourself a country terrain dipping so sharply that at a certain distance the eye cannot reach the valley; and a row of trees, whose ending is lost to sight, either because of the length of the row, or because it is running down hill, etc. A factory, a tower, etc., seen so that it seems to stand alone above the horizon, which is out of sight, produces a most effective and sublime contrast between the finite and the indefinite, etc.⁴

If the contrast of infinite and indefinite produces a series of sensations in the poet's mind, the contrast of finite and indefinite, of physical landscape as opposed to immensity, is the spark for poetic creation. In Leopardi, finite and indefinite are opposite, complementary entities, antipoetic and poetic matter. This contrast is reflected in the idyll's lexicon. Leopardi, as Brose remarks, divides lexicon into two basic categories, *termini* and *parole*, a distinction that reflects the dual nature of language. Scientific and philosophical languages deal in terms which present a univocal idea of a given object or concept: these *termini* fix meaning and delimit semantic flexibility. *Parole*, conversely, do not present a precise idea of an object, but are polysemic and call up clusters of images that, by virtue of their indefiniteness, suggest the infinite. In *L'Infinito*, a lexical dichotomy is perceivable between precise, referential terms, like *colle* and *siepe*, opposed to vague, poetic words, like *pensier* and *eterno*. The terms describing a physical reality are not important in themselves but only as antitheses to words, as boundaries to be transcended through the action of imagination.⁵ As a result of this dialectical process, terms describing natural reality are belittled, divested of their referential value; conversely, words that convey an idea of limitless indeterminacy, like *spazio* and *silenzio*, are amplified, semantically pluralized into *spazi* and *silenzi*.

Whereas the formal structure of *L'Infinito* faithfully conforms to the greater Romantic lyric identified by Abrams, the philosophical conclusions of the idyll move away from Romanticism. In the synthesis of the

dialectic process that closes *L'Infinito* – the thought disappearing in the infinite – there is no suggestion of that mystical fusion with the universe that can be found in many Romantic poets and philosophers. There is no echo of that unity of universe that was at the basis, for instance, of Schelling's transcendental philosophy. For Schelling, spirit is nature come to the stage of clarity and consciousness, and nature is spirit still in its visible, undeveloped stage. Mind and nature thus have a common origin, and their identity can be found in the Absolute, where all antitheses disappear. In *L'Infinito*, this synthesis does not occur at the meeting point of nature and mind but only in the poet's mind, not at the hedge but on this side of the hedge, not in nature but in imagination. The central point in the idyll where the synthesizing process begins is also its quasi-symmetrical center, the first part of the seventh line, *io nel pensiero mi fingo*. In Leopardi's lexicon, *fingere* is not simulation but rather invention through poetic meditation: it is through the act of fiction that all antitheses in the end disappear. As many critics have remarked, however, the closing of *L'Infinito* should not be read according to the philosophy of idealism. It does not suggest a fusion with the object of external perception: the ideas. It is instead imbued with sensationalism, more specifically with the Lockean psychology⁶: the drowning of thought into the immensity is a merging of feeling into spirituality. In this final image, as De Sanctis has remarked, one should not see a denial of life but rather the supreme value of sensation.

Structure of *L'Infinito*

Leopardi's idyll has been defined as an *itinerarium mentis in infinitum*, in which the mind, after going through a progression of contrasts and binary oppositions – past/present, subject/object, silence/sound, proximity/distance – reaches its final liberation through the faculty of imagination. Its structure can be described as symmetrical or specularly symmetrical, depending on which element is being emphasized. The idyll opens with an indefinite temporal marker, *sempre*, a nonspatial continuum in which events can occur in succession from the present to the past or in a reversed succession, from the past to the present. What follows on the same line, however, the other temporal marker *fu* and the deictic *questo*, make clear that the direction of narration is from past to present. The time progression is further defined by the present tense *esclude* and by the two presents progressive *seden-*

do and mirando. Another present progressive appears in the 11th line, *vo comparando*, which introduces a reversal in the interplay of past/present: *le morte stagioni* are brought back to the present by means of memory. The following qualifying adjective *presente*, the deictic *questa*, and the present tense *s'annega*, reestablish the previous temporal direction, from past to present. The final time marker in the poem is the present infinitive *nafragare*, a verb form that functions as a substantive while retaining its verbal characteristic: *nafragare* concludes emblematically all the previous time shifts by mirroring the undetermined temporal dimension of the initial *sempre*.

The contrastive structure of the idyll is also visible in the relationship of subject and object. In the first two lines, the narrating *I* and the natural landscape represented by the nouns *colle* and *siepe*, are conjoined by the pronoun *mi* and by the adjective *caro*, both qualifying the object in terms of its relation to the subject. Object and subject seem to depart in the third line, when the description moves from the hill to the farthest horizon; however, the complementarity of narrating *I* and nature is immediately reinstated: *l'ultimo orizzonte* is in fact defined in terms of the poet's vision, *il guardo*. Nonetheless, this time the sequential order of subject/object is inverted, a reversal that is a prelude to the greater semantic inversion introduced in the fourth line by the adversative conjunction *ma*. Here, the object is reflected in the poet's mind, as in an endless series of mirrors: the outer horizon, internalized and multiplied, becomes an endless succession of *spazi*. The adjacency of subject and object is enhanced in line 11 by the medial diathesis of the intransitive verb *sovvenire*, introduced by the first-person indirect object pronoun: *mi sovviene*. *l'eterno* is halfway between *I* remember and it comes to my mind. The process of internalization of the object is completed in the last two lines, when the thought flows into the sea of immensity: as in the first line, subject and object, the doer and the receiver of the action, are combined.

The same contrastive structure is applicable to those nouns and adjectives in the idyll that refer to silence and sound. The first allusion to sound, or rather to the absence of it, occurs in lines 5 and 6, in the enjambement *sovruman silenzi*, an expression that contains in itself both subject (human) and object (silence). *Profondissima quiete* could be considered a useless pleonasm, since *quiete* indicates absence of noise as well as absence of movement, except for the

fact that its image contains an inverted symmetry of *sovruman silenzi*: the prefix *super-* works in contrast to the superlative suffix *-issimo*: *sovruman silenzi* and *quiete profondissima* describe silence extending far upward and far downward. Sound reappears in line 8. The rustling of *il vento* is in conjunction with the narrating *I*, implicit in the verb *odo*. This is the sound that activates the imaginative process in the poet's mind. Sound is again contrasted to silence in the next line, through the comparison of *infinito silenzio* to *questa voce*. In the last line, the two elements finally merge: the lively sound of the present season disappears, flowing into the eternal sea of silence.

The spatial contrast in *L'Infinito* is determined by the several demonstrative adjectives *questo* and *quello*, expressing proximity and distance, respectively, and strategically positioned in the idyll. The initial deictics *quest'ermo colle* and *questa siepe* in lines 1 and 2 are set in opposition to *di là da quella* in line 5, a feminine demonstrative adjective probably referring to the feminine noun *siepe*. The poet's eye focuses first on the hill, then on the hedge, and then his vision converges on the *interminati spazi* beyond them. This alternate sequence of proximity and distance anticipates the other series of deictics in lines 9 and 10, where *queste piante* and *questa voce* are set in opposition to *quello infinito silenzio*. Here the deictics provide a metaleptic substitution of the visual field with the aural field, as the rustling wind calls forth the reaction of the poet's imagination.⁷ In the final section, the metalepsis is reversed: *questa immensità* and *questo mare* entail a shift from the aural field to the spatial field. In the last line, proximity finally prevails over distance, as imagination prevails over reality.

Symmetries and inversions in *L'Infinito* are reflected in the phonetic structure of some of its lexemes. Margaret Brose maintains that *L'Infinito* is built upon a chiasmic pattern, and that all the inversions converge upon a central axis located in lines 7 and 8. A double phonetic chiasmus, Brose says, can be seen between the first and last lines, *caro / mare*, and *colle / dolce*: The phonetic chiasmus is intensified by the euphonic recurrence of *ar* in the last line, *nafragar/mare*; as well as its inversion in the virtual center of the poem's central line: *spaura*. It recurs again (in an extended form conflating *ar+ra*) in the key verb denoting the poem's structure: *comparando*.⁸

In *L'Infinito*, all these tightly controlled patterns of symmetries and inversions are encapsulated in a loose

syntactic and prosodic frame. Some critics have suggested that Leopardi used this laxness of formal structure intentionally to imitate the free flow of thoughts and mental associations. *L'Infinito* is in blank hendecasyllables, a form that frees the poet from the restraints of rhyme. Even in its most canonic configuration, regular hendecasyllable is still the most varied and free metrical form in Italian verse. The rhythm of the hendecasyllable is predominantly iambic, and its stresses fall on the even syllables. Other than a required stress on the 10th syllable, however, there is no specific rule requiring stresses to be in a certain position. The rhythmic effects that can be created by this accentual elasticity are extremely varied. Common usage has the rhythmic accents placed on the fourth and the sixth syllable, although these two stresses do not occur at the same time but in alternation.⁹ The prosodic variability in *L'Infinito* can be exemplified through the pivotal lines 4 through 6, pivotal in the sense that they introduce the stream of thoughts of the poet: (4) *Ma sedendo e mirando, interminati/* (5) *spazi di là da quella, e sovrumani /* (6) *silenzi, e profondissima qu'ete.* In all three lines, the sixth syllable is stressed, but their rhythm in the initial part is quite different. In the fourth line, the stress on the third syllable and the main stress on the sixth produce an anapest; in the fifth line, the stress falls on the first and on the fourth syllable, creating a dactyltrochaic rhythm; in the sixth line, there is a strong stress on the second syllable and another one on the sixth, so that only by emphasizing the light stress on the first syllable of *profondissima* it is possible to create an iambic rhythm. In the final part of all three lines, there are no marked stresses between the sixth and the 10th syllables. Furthermore, because of the use of enjambement, the stresses on the last syllables are hardly noticeable. The prosodic flexibility in these lines, as in the rest of the poem, is also made possible by the careful alternation of bisyllabic and multisyllabic words.¹⁰

In addition to metric flexibility, *L'Infinito* is also characterized by the lack of a rigid syntactic structure and by the presence of ambiguous connective nexuses. Both factors contribute to enhancing the sense of indeterminacy that the poem conveys, because syntactic flexibility brings semantic ambiguity: *ove*, for instance, is a polysyntactical conjunction, in the sense that it can be interpreted as a locative as well as a consecutive conjunction (where or whereas); *come* is a conjunction expressing time (when), but it could also be interpreted as causative (as, since). The

second part of the idyll is instead characterized by polysyndeton. The repeated use of the conjunction *e* in such close succession is not just a rhetorical device but rather is clearly evocative of the mental poetic process: the use of coordinating conjunctions expresses a continuous stream of images as opposed to a discrete series of events.

As Brose remarks, all the prosodic elements in *L'Infinito* (rhythm, polysyndeton, enjambements) combine with the phonic elements (dieresis, synaloepha, and assonance) to create a continuous melodic flow.¹¹ The analysis of the internal structure of this idyll, in fact, would not be complete without at least mentioning the precision of its phonetic system, meticulously dissected by various critics,¹² like the melodious succession of sounds obtained through the balance of open and closed vowels in bisyllabic words (*qui te, qu s-to, qu llo, v nto, v ce, m rte, d lce, m re*); or like the careful avoidance of perfect rhymes in favor of assonances and consonances, obtained through the recurrence of certain vowels and consonants (9 *p* s, 12 *s* s, and 14 *r* s in the first eight verses; 14 *e* s in the first three verses). The terseness of the phonetic system, the paucity of dependent clauses, the ordinariness of lexicon, all combine to create an apparent effect of naturalness and simplicity, resulting, to use Momigliano's definition, in a sublime poverty of style.¹³

***L'Infinito*: Its Translatability and Untranslatability**

The apparent stylistic simplicity of *L'Infinito* hides, in reality, an extremely refined poetic structure, polished to the most infinitesimal detail, as an examination of the original manuscripts proves. With its total coherence of design among all its elements, *L'Infinito* exemplifies what Croce called the indivisibility of the aesthetic expression, the identity of form and substance on which he based his notion of untranslatability. The first English translators and critics at once recognized the virtual impossibility of properly rendering *L'Infinito* into a different language. As Ghan Singh points out in his study on Leopardi and England, however, the early commentators were unable to separate general problems of language from specific problems caused by Leopardi's style and lexicon. H.F. Brown, in his review of the first translation of *L'Infinito* by Townsend, attributed part of the infelicities in the English version to the difficulty of rendering Italian polysyllables into English monosyllables. Another set of difficulties, in Brown's

view, arose from the content: Leopardi's poetry, Brown contends, is immense in scope, while at the same time lacking in detail, probably referring to Leopardi's preference for vague words. As to style, the reviewer says that Leopardi is a rhetorical poet, in the sense that the rhythms of his poetry are dictated by the reciting voice and the listening ear. All these factors, combined with his disposition to deviate from regular metric patterns, make Leopardi a perplexing author to render into English.¹⁴ Also for the anonymous reviewer of *The Poems of Leopardi* translated by Morrison, the arbitrary adaptation of meter is one of the main difficulties in rendering Leopardi's poetry into English. According to the reviewer, to translate the free structure of Leopardi's modern ode requires a greater mastery than to render more rigid forms, like the ancient sonnet or the madrigal. The reviewer casts his doubts about the possibility of ever having a perfect translation of Leopardi into English.¹⁵ His comment was prophetic.

As the poet Vernon Watkins remarked years later, many have translated *L'Infinito*, but no one has ever succeeded in rendering it into English, so elusive is its cadence. Most of the English translators of *L'Infinito* have tried to solve the problem of its irregular prosody by exploiting the affinity of blank verse with free hendecasyllable. Blank verse is basically iambic pentameter, an unrhymed decasyllable that imitates the caesuras and enjambements of classical hexameter.¹⁶ The fact that the two types of verse are built on a similar measure does not mean that they can be substituted one for the other. The imperfect correspondence of Italian free hendecasyllable and pentameter has been highlighted by Lascelles Abercrombie, in his *Principles of English Prosody*. Abercrombie quotes Leopardi's *Canti* as an example of irregular versification, in which meter is the result of variable patterns in a nonregular order. Leopardi's *Canti* are here described as part-rhymed verse and are compared to the irregular versification in Milton's *Samson Agonistes*. The verse of Leopardi, Abercrombie maintains, has nothing in common with the varied irregularity of Milton's poetry. English verse, for Abercrombie, can bear a greater irregularity without ceasing to be metrical, whereas a slight divergence from the regular pattern is sufficient to create an anomalous prosody in Italian verse.¹⁷ Therefore, it is not possible, despite the claims of a scholar like Postgate, to base poetry translation on a set of mathematically established correspondences between metrical forms.¹⁸

Imitation from one language to another, says Figueroa, *has to be sua operatione*: what /s/s do in

one language, we have no reason to believe is what /s/s do in another; what dactylic hexameter did for Homer it does not do for modern English.¹⁹ Even if a perfect correspondence of the two systems of versification existed—a dovetail match between hendecasyllable and pentameter—it would not be a guarantee of correct metrical transposition. The translated text must be independent from the movement of the original phrasing and find its own natural movement, according to the inborn rhythm and musicality of the target language.²⁰ As Mounin remarks, if all the difficulty of translating consisted in establishing a counterpart between forms, the problem of translation would have long since been solved. The exterior faithfulness to the exterior musicality of a poetic work produces ineffective translations. Fidelity to form is inadvisable, except in those rare cases of intentionally imitative musicality, for instance in the translation of a poem like Verlaine's *Chanson d'automne*. This prescription can be extended to all the grammatical and syntactical aspects of the poem. In *L'Infinito*, Mounin says, there is an inversion in the first verse, two gerunds in the fourth, a durative in the 11th, an infinitive used as a noun in the last. In the name of grammatical faithfulness, some French translations say *Toujours il me fut cher ce coteau solitaire*, an inversion that is a rhythmic nonsense; *assis l et regardant*, which is pseudo-French; *je m en vais comparant*, an archaism already obsolete in 18th-century French; *il m est doux de naufrager*, so unusual that is almost unintelligible, mainly because *naufrager* improperly acquires a transitive meaning.²¹ Like metrical form, syntactic and grammatical forms also are deeply rooted in the language structure and cannot be transferred from one language to another. The Italian sentence structure derives from Latin, and like Latin it is characterized by parataxis (albeit in a lesser degree). As the studies by Auerbach on Latin have shown, given the centrality and flexibility of syntax in language structure, style acquires a strategic importance in composition. Syntactic articulation not only offers the possibility to build complex subordinate clauses but also allows a greater suppleness in reasoning. A different word order in two languages might therefore be the external sign of a deeper difference in conceptualization. Unlike Italian, English syntax is quite simple, and it favors coordinate clauses and a quite rigid sentence structure. The distortion caused by retaining the word order of *L'Infinito* is even greater in an English translation than in a French translation, because English is more divergent from Italian syntax than French is. Always dear to me was

this lonely hill the syntactic calque of *Sempre caro mi fu quest'ermo colle* is not only rhythmically off-balance, but its eccentric displacement of words also diffracts semantic transmission. In short, using Popović's definition of equivalence, it can be said that a *linguistic equivalence* of *L'Infinito* is only partially possible, given the limited homogeneity of the two languages. The same can be said for a *paradigmatic equivalence*, because the two linguistic systems have a limited grammatical and syntactic affinity. What can instead be attempted in an English translation is a *stylistic equivalence* (that is, a functional equivalence of elements in both original and translation aiming at an expressive identity with an invariant of identical meaning) and a *textual equivalence* (that is, the equivalence of the syntagmatic structure of a text).

The translator of *L'Infinito*, Buffoni maintains, must aim for a rendition not dictated by original metrics or syntax, a rendition halfway between the poetic license of Lowell: That hill pushed off by itself was always dear/to me, and the hedges near/it that cut away the final horizon and the prosaic rendering of Kay: It was always dear to me, this solitary hill, and this hedge which shuts off the gaze from so large a part of the uttermost horizon.²² This translation should serve as a bridge connecting the reader to the original and should carry all the elements contained in the idyll with propriety and restraint. What is needed, Buffoni concludes, is not faithfulness to the original but loyalty.²³ To convey all the elements of *L'Infinito* is obviously impossible, given the proven inseparability of its form and content. What a translation respectful of the original should instead try to convey is its essential element, or in Popović's terminology, to provide an invariant of identical meaning. The essence of this idyll, as Leopardi said in the *Zibaldone*, lies in the contrast between *infinito* and *indefinito*. This contrast, as seen before, is obtained through a set of symmetries and inverted symmetries that can be summarized thus: (1) finite vs. infinite; (2) parole vs. termini; (3) subject vs. object; (4) silence vs. sound; (5) proximity vs. distance; (6) past vs. present; (7) bisyllables vs. multisyllables; (8) singular vs. plural; and (9) coordinating conjunctions vs. subordinate conjunctions. These are, to use William Frost's definition, the pillar symbols of Leopardi's idyll. The contrast between these elements is the axis on which a respectful translation of *L'Infinito* must revolve, the yardstick by which its effectiveness can be measured. The poetic success or failure of the various translations of *L'Infinito* can be determined by

how effectively, semantically and stylistically, the translator is able to convey these pillar symbols compatibly with the resources and limitations of the target language.

The Infinite

The contrast between finite and indefinite is implicit in the idyll's title. *Infinito*, which derives from the Latin *infinitus*, is in fact a compound formed by the prefix *in-* (not) + *finitus* (finite). The title also contains an insoluble grammatical ambiguity, because *infinito* is both a noun and an adjective used as a noun. The same ambiguity was contained in the original title, *Sopra l'infinito*, eventually discarded by Leopardi. *Sopra* means *above* in this case the title *Sopra l'infinito* would refer to the location of the hill overlooking an invisible valley as well as *on*, *about* in this case the title would suggest a meditation on boundlessness. In either case, *infinito* could still be intended both as a noun and as an adjective. Although in Italian this grammatical distinction is mainly academic, the question of whether *infinito* is a noun or an adjective used as a noun is of some relevance for the translator when the target language differentiates between the two forms. Rilke, for instance, facing in his German version the insoluble dilemma noun or adjective, *Unendliche* or *Unendlichkeit*, decided to leave the title untranslated.²⁴ In English, *infinite* as an adjective and as a noun have the same form, although *infinite* is more commonly used as an adjective than as a noun. In the *American Heritage Dictionary*, *infinite* as an adjective is defined as 1. Having no boundaries or limits, and 2. Immeasurably great, as in duration or extent. *Infinite* as a noun is defined as something infinite. With the only exception of Barricelli, who leaves his translation untitled, in 11 of the 12 English versions here analyzed the translator renders the title as *The Infinite*, thus leaving the ambiguity unsolved. However, what most translators disregard is that *l'infinito* in the title is in strict correlation to *l'eterno* in line 11, which can also be an adjective or a noun. If *L'infinito* indicates the absence of limits in space, then *l'eterno* indicates the absence of limits in time; if *L'Infinito* is rendered as *The Infinite*, then out of consistency *l'eterno* should be rendered as *the eternal*. Only three translators establish a connection between the two terms (Lowell, Flores, and Nichols). Townsend translates *l'eterno* as *the eternal things*, so opting for the adjective form,

and Smith translates it as the eternity of time, opting for the noun form. All the others (Morrison, Cliffe, Trevelyan, Heath-Stubbs, Casale, Barricelli, Fowler) translate it as eternity, choosing to use a noun without the definite article. Eternity points indirectly at what could be a different and perhaps more accurate solution for the title: Infinity. Although it is a noun, infinity carries the senses of both adjective and noun, quality and object: again, according to the definition in *The American Heritage Dictionary*, infinity indicates the quality or condition of being infinite and also unbounded space, time, or quantity.

If the distinction between noun and adjective is basically of little or no consequence for the English translator, to establish the function of the article *l* before *infinito* is instead important, because here the usage of English and Italian differs. Whereas in Italian the definite article is required before specific nouns and also before nouns used in a general or abstract sense, in English it is required only in the first case. The English translator has then to determine whether the *l* before *infinito* is used strictly as a deictic, pointing at a specific infinite, in which case the article should be retained, or whether it is used in a general or abstract sense, in which case it should be omitted. Not even the analysis of the original title can be helpful in solving the dilemma. *Sopra l'infinito* suggests separation: of the poet from the surrounding space, and of the poem from its content. Leopardi willfully eliminated this idea of separation with the new title *L'Infinito*.²⁵ The last line in the idyll, with the dispersion of thought into immensity, also dispels any suggestion of separation. According to this interpretation, the title should refer to infinity in an abstract sense. If this is the case, the definite article should be omitted in the English translation, because its use would delimit what is instead boundless. Other images in the idyll: *quello infinito silenzio*, *questa immensità*, *questo mare*, however, seem to suggest that the poet is indeed referring to a specific infinity: in this case, the definite article should be retained.

The contrast between definite and indefinite also finds expression through the opposition of *parole* and *termini*. As discussed before, *parole* in Leopardi convey indeterminate ideas and are poetic; *termini*, on the contrary, indicate precise objects and are antipoeitic. In *L'Infinito*, vague words like *pensiero* and *eterno* can be regarded as *parole*, and well-defined natural objects like *colle* and *siepe* as *termini*. To retain this lexical distinction in an English translation is

particularly important, in consideration of the fact that English tends to emphasize the effect of clarity, and it can potentially turn *parole* into *termini*. Nonetheless, the English terms adopted by most translators, *thought* and *eternal* on the one side, and *hill* and *hedge* on the other, can be considered adequate equivalents. In Leopardi, poeticalness is also expressed through the use of synonyms. Using a word that has a meaning similar but not identical to the meaning of another word amplifies its semantic field. The conceptual reverberation so created also produces an effect of indeterminacy comparable to that of *parole*. In *L'Infinito*, there are two pairs of near synonyms, *silenzio* / *quiete*, and *annegare* / *naufragare*. *Silenzio* implies absence of noise, whereas *quiete* implies both the absence of noise and of movement. Again, finding adequate synonyms in English should not be a problem, also considering its richness in lexicon. All the English translations examined differentiate between the two terms, although the equivalents they use are not always accurate. Townsend and Morrison resort to the pair *silence* and *rest*. In this coupling, the original semantic affinity between *silenzio* and *quiete* is partly lost, because *rest* describes only inactivity, without any specific reference to movement or silence. The same thing can be said for the pair *silence* and *calm* (Trevelyan, Barricelli, Fowler). The main senses of *calm* are nearly or completely motionless and not agitated. *Calm* is a closer semantic match compared with *rest*; it too is slightly out of focus, because it does not explicitly convey the idea of silence. The same can be said for *silence* and *peace* in Casale's translation: the primary sense of *peace* is serenity, rather than absence of movement or sound. *Silence* and *quiet* (Cliffe, Stubbs, Flores, Nichols) and *silence* and *quietude* (Smith) are semantically closer to the original, because *quiet* can refer to something both making no noise, and/or not moving. Curiously, no translator resorts to *still* or *stillness*, which carry exactly the same spatial and aural meanings as implied in the original. The other pair of near synonyms in *L'Infinito* is *s'annega* and *naufragare*. *S'annega* is the middle intransitive form of *annegare*, whose literal meaning is to drown. Here Leopardi uses it in a figurative sense as to dissolve: *my thought is dissolving into immensity*. *Naufragare*, literally to be wrecked or shipwrecked, is also intransitive, and also it is used figuratively as to sink or to lose oneself. Also in this case, all the English translations differentiate between

the two terms, and also in this case, the equivalents found are not always semantically accurate. One solution is the pair *drowned* and *shipwreck* (Townsend, Smith, Trevelyan), or also *drowning* and *wreck* (Morrison). The English *to drown* and *to shipwreck* both convey a stronger physical and metaphorical sense than the Italian *annegarsi* and *nafragare*. *To drown* in the intransitive form is *to die by suffocating in water or another liquid*. The verb *to drown* can be used figuratively only in the transitive form, as *to deaden one's awareness of*, as by immersion, for instance in the sentence *to drown one's cares in drink*.

To shipwreck, for its part, is only transitive, and it means literally *to cause a ship or its passengers to suffer shipwreck*, and figuratively *to ruin utterly*. This latter sense distorts the meaning of the original: *il naufragar m' dölce in questo mare* does not suggest destruction, but rather willful surrender. The other pairs, *go down* and *wreck* (Lowell), *drifted on* and *wreck* (Cliffe), suffer from the opposite defect, because both *to go down* and *to drift on* are too generic and do not carry the physical quality of *s' annega*. The same can be said for *drowned* and *sinking* (Nichols) and *drown* and *lose* (Flores). The strength and beauty of the two verbs *s' annega* and *naufagar*, as critics have noted, lie in the images they convey, in the fact that their literal meaning does not overshadow the figurative sense. The other pairs *drowned* and *foundering* (Stubbs, Casale, Barricelli) and *founders* and *shipwreck* (Fowlers) retain better the original balance of figurative and literal. *Founder*, in particular, is more closely semantically related to the original: *to founder* is an intransitive verb coming from the Latin *fundus*, meaning *bottom*, and it evokes the image of a sinking ship.

This semantic comparative study can also be applied to the other binary oppositions identified as coming from the Latin *fundus*, meaning *bottom*, and originally referred to a ship's sinking in *L'Infinito* (subject/object, silence/sound, etc.). This analysis, however, cannot abstract from the other formal components of the poem. The effectiveness by which these binary oppositions are rendered in translation must be set against the form the translators have elected to use. According to the classification proposed by Lefevere, the 12 translations here analyzed can be divided into the following categories: rhymed translation: Morrison; poetry into prose: Smith; blank verse: Townsend, Cliffe, Trevelyan, Heath-Stubbs, Casale, Barricelli, Nichols; interpretation: (imitation) Lowell, (version) Flores, Fowler.

Translations

In the introduction to his *Masterpieces of Giacomo Leopardi*, a selection of poems rendered in prose, William Fletcher Smith acknowledges that prose translation cannot convey the artistry of the original verse. The obvious disadvantage of prose rendition is that it cannot reproduce all those connotative effects created by verse through the position of words in the line or through their organization in more lines. William Ellery Leonard has thus summarized the advantages of verse compared with prose:

- (1) verse permits a wider and more apposite choice of syntactical constructions than the more conventional idioms of prose; (2) verse gives to the many repetitions of ideas, words, phrases, and clauses, which in a prose translation often seem mere jejune verbosity, their proper relevance and copiousness...; (3) verse, by its very cadences, by its metrical emphases, possesses, for driving home the central meanings and for distinguishing the nicer contrasts and other relations of the ideas, an instrument scarcely available in the more pedestrian rhythms of prose.²⁶

For its part, prose has the advantage compared with verse of allowing a choice of words that are semantically closer to the original, because words can be selected for their denotative value rather than for their formal value (like length or stress pattern).²⁷ A prose rendition of verse usually aims at giving semantic rather than aesthetic information, because it cannot carry some of the unforeseeable qualities of verse: a possible surprising sign or a surprising order in which signs are arranged.²⁸ The advantage of prose rendition is also stylistic. Because prose can avoid the restrictions of meter, it is usually more adherent to the structure of the target language. This results in a natural, flowing style that shuns the phonetic and syntactic syncopation characteristic of many verse translations. Because of the contrasting demands of source language and target language, however, no translator can keep entirely to his preestablished parameters. Translations of poetry into prose, as Lefevere says, are usually fairly elegant in language, avoiding the distortions and verbal antics one finds in verse translations. They are accurate, closer to the source text than a verse translation could ever be. On closer investigation, however, prose translation

turns out to be less respectable than tradition would have us believe. It results in an uneasy, hybrid structure, forever groping towards a precarious equilibrium between verse and prose and never really achieving it.²⁹ The analysis of Smith's version reveals in fact fluctuations in both directions. The first sentence,

Always dear to me was this lonely hill and this hedge that from so great a space of the horizon shuts off my sight, follows the syntactic order of the original so closely that it is actually closer to a literal translation than to prose. The inversion *dear to me was* in the first sentence (*caro mi fu*), and *I go comparing* in the third sentence (*vo comparando*) are both grammatical calques of the original forms. These obviously are not oversights on the part of the translator but rather a deliberate search for stylistic effect. As Lefevere remarks, the prose translator has much looser control over the rhythm of the text because he has abandoned the verse form. Therefore, to compensate for this loss, he has to look for other ways in which to achieve an effect similar to that of the source text. One option available to him is to model the syntax of his target text closely on that of the source text, even though this process might lead to sentences that sound very contorted.³⁰ The prose translator also has to compensate for the loss of emphasis that the original poet might have placed on certain words, because he cannot direct the attention of the reader to specific terms or images the way poetry can. The visual leveling of words is particularly detrimental in *L'Infinito*, a poem whose communicative value lies to a large extent in the visual arrangement of words. This can be seen in the many complementary terms strategically positioned in the line or connecting distant lines and in the several enjambements that create a tension between a line and the other. The prose translator must therefore try to make up for these losses in communicative value. To make a word stand out in prose, one option available to the translator is to charge that word with connotative values, even if it means to deviate from its strict semantic meaning. In other words, the translator can give a poetic touch to his prose. In doing so, however, he implicitly moves away from prose and toward verse, thus contradicting his own premises. In Smith's version, a trace of poetic embellishment can be seen in the term *supernal*, used to render *sovrumani*. *Sovrumani* stands out in the verse because it is part of an enjambement and also because, like *interminati*, its syllabic length slows down the enunciation, so drawing the reader's attention. *Supernal* carries a slight semantic shift from *sovruman*

mani: whereas *sovrumani/Silenzi* refers to silence considered from a human perspective and has no mystical implication, the poetic adjective *supernal* transports it to a celestial, heavenly altitude. Smith's version deviates from the poem's communicative value in another instance as well. The translator disregards reproducing the vital symmetrical relation connecting the end of line 1, *quest'ermo colle*, to the last line, *questo mare*. Although he translates correctly the first unit of the dyad as *This lonely hill*, he chooses for the sake of elegance to render the second with *such a sea*. His choices basically reflect the fact that there is not a clear dividing line separating poetry and prose. The prose translator, whenever he sees the opportunity, has to trespass his self-imposed boundaries to take full advantage of subtleties of style and musicality.

In the introduction to his translations, Smith says he chose prose over verse because prose served him better in his attempt to convey the spirit of Leopardi through the images of his poems. The visual component of poetry, which Pound called *Phanopoeia*, that is the casting of images upon the visual imagination, is in fact one of the elements that can be more easily transferred from one language to another.³¹ The success of a transferred image, the American translator Jay Smith says, can be regarded as a sign of good poetry. For instance, in any translation of Dante, you would know immediately that he was a great poet, because, even in the abstract passages there're always these marvelous concrete, visual images which can't be destroyed in translation.³² The transfer of images, however, is not totally successful in this version of *L'Infinito*, and for that matter in all the other English versions as well. However, one cannot infer from this that Leopardi is not a great poet. The problem with *L'Infinito* is not its lack of images – on the contrary, it could be said that the poem relies almost entirely on visual imagination – but that its images are not always concrete. This is once again a result of Leopardi's contiguous use of *parole* and *termini*. Images of nature, like *colle*, *siepe*, and *piante*, obviously transfer well, whereas the same cannot be said for the other nouns and verbs that express indeterminacy. Images in Leopardi are precise, and at the same time their outlines are blurred. The final sentence in Smith's version: *Thus in this immensity my thought is drowned; and sweet to me is shipwreck in such a sea*, although it gains in exactitude, does not have the same visual power as the original. This reveals what is perhaps the greatest danger inherent in prose translation. Because prose places its

emphasis upon semantic communication, it tends to clarify those elements of vagueness, mystery, and silence that the original poet had deftly embedded in his words. In short, the danger in prose translation is to shed light on what should instead be an *écriture d'ombres*.³³

Morrison's rhymed version obtains the opposite effect, creating more shadows than those already contained in the original. In the introductory preamble to his translations of Leopardi's *Canti*, Morrison starts by saying he has kept clear of paraphrasing. Here, Morrison is probably referring to Dryden's well-known definition of paraphrase as 'translation with latitude', that is, where the author is kept in view by the translator, so as never to be lost, but his words are not so strictly followed as his sense; and that too is admitted to be amplified, but not altered. Morrison's stated goal is to provide a rendition that is faithful and at the same time not slavish. However, what strikes the reader immediately in collating the original and the translation is the evident divergence from the original in both form and content.

Morrison's version mirrors the fascination with end rhyming by the Victorian translators. His version is in pentameter stanzas, and its verses are organized in quatrains, in alternate rhymes (ABBA). A coherent patterned division like this creates, as Stauffer says, 'a feeling that the thought, too, must be coherent: rhymes and stanzas hold the thought together.'³⁴ The main problem with applying such a rigid structure to *L'Infinito* is that thought is forced to progress in suspended sequences, whereas in the original its progression is almost uninterrupted. John Heath-Stubbs, a blank-verse translator of *L'Infinito*, remarks that what distinguishes Leopardi from other contemporary Romantic poets is precisely the role of imagination, that is, imagination is an instrument that produces, simultaneously or in rapid succession, the most disparate images, keeping the mind in a state of continuous activity.³⁵ As previously stated, in *L'Infinito*, thought overrides the line division through enjambement: in run-on lines, the metrical pause does not coincide with the conceptual pause, and the thread of logic continues to the next line. Unlike run-on lines, end-stopped lines are self-contained, and suggest a sense of conclusion. Even though Morrison also uses enjambements, these do not connect the same terms as the original, and their power is somehow limited by rhyme-links. The artificial caging of thought in Morrison's translation is evident, for instance, in the passage from the third to the fourth

stanza: I hear surge through the rustling leaves that sway / I aye compare its whispers with that all / Pervading silence deep, and I recall / Eternity, and ages passed away!// The present lives... Here, the English version introduces a stoppage after away, emphasized by the exclamation mark, absent in the original (e le morte stagioni/e la presente). Furthermore, Morrison distorts the meaning of the whole following line, first by rendering la presente [stagione] as the present lives; second, by introducing a foreign body into the line, and all its stress with me. This Tennysonian lament, totally absent in the original, is used to fulfill the metrical expectations of the line, which is a perfect iambic pentameter. The rhyming translator, Lefevere says, does not tie himself to the metre of the source text, as the purely metrical translator usually does, but he soon finds out that the restrictions of a self-imposed metre are just as severe. Unlike his metrical colleague he must always be on the look-out for the right rhyme-word, and he is therefore even more restricted in his freedom of choice.³⁶ In case he does not find the right rhyme-word, Lefevere adds, he might decide to settle for a poor rhyme or assonance. In Morrison's version, this shows in the last stanza, in the imperfect rhyming of infinite and sight. When even these rhyme-saving devices fail, Lefevere adds, the translator might be forced to distort not just a word, but an entire line to achieve his aim: this is the ultimate and worst subterfuge the rhyming translator is forced to use if he is to preserve his rhyme.³⁷ In Morrison, distortions are visible, for instance, in the first line in the third stanza, I hear surge through the rustling leaves that sway. To create the rhyme away/sway, Morrison once more introduces an image absent in the original, that of the swaying leaves (not to mention the noun leaves itself, which is a synecdoche of piante). The same can be said for breast, in the third line of the second stanza, which replaces the original cor, here used, one suspects, for its rhyming with rest.

Finding the right rhymes, Lefevere says, solves only half of the problem. Ending a line is one thing, and filling it with the right number of stresses is another. One very often finds that, precisely because he is so concerned with ending the line in the prescribed way, the rhymer does not have enough material to put into it. To procure the necessary number of words or stresses, says Lefevere, the translator can obviate with superfluous modifiers (either expanding words or through tautology) and unconnected stopgaps (an improvised substitute for something lacking), which sometimes

makes the lines into which they are inserted much more contorted than they need to be.³⁸ The use of fillers is obvious in Morrison's rhymed version: although English is a more synthetic language than Italian, Morrison expands Leopardi's poem from the original 15 lines to 16. A superfluous modifier can be seen here in the pleonastic use of two adjectives, unbroke, and unfathomed, to render the five syllable of *profondissima*; a case of stopgap is the adverb *Howe'er*, clearly inserted as a filler: also the synalepha reveals that its main function is to accommodate the required number of syllables.

Several balances and oppositions are lost in the translation a result of the superimposition of a stanzaic form. In the original, for instance, the relationship of subject and object finds an equilibrium in the medial verbs, those constructions in which the poetic subject is not the grammatical subject but meets the object halfway: *Io nel pensier mi fingo, e mi sovvien l'eterno*. In Morrison, the two are rendered as *my thoughts at will do summon scenes of boundless space behind and I recall/eternity*, respectively. In the former, the use of the possessive adjective *my* is an adequate substitute for the medial form, in the latter the syntactic construction is subject—verb—direct object, which implies a separation of subject and object. A rendition for the latter could have been, for instance, *to my mind eternity occurs* (Cliffe), which contains a possessive adjective and so would have saved the symmetrical relationship. In this case, very likely the choice of the transitive *recall* has been dictated by its rhyming with *all*. This is not the only case of disregarded symmetry. The contrast *silence/sound* (*quello infinito silenzio and questa voce*) is rendered by Morrison as *I aye compare its [the wind's] whispers with that all / Pervading silence*. His translation contains an unjustified shift from the singular (*voce*) to the plural (*whispers*). Conversely, in the opposition *singular/plural silenzio and silenzi*, for syllabic reasons there is a shift from the plural to the singular, *silence and not silences, space and not spaces*. Another case of missed symmetry, this time not ascribable to metrics but simply to misinterpretation, regards the fundamental opposition of proximity and distance, conveyed through the deictics *questo* and *quello*. This opposition could be easily duplicable in the target language: English makes a similar distinction between the demonstrative adjectives *this* and *that*, the latter being the farther removed. Instead of *this hedge, and this hill*, as properly rendered in many other transla-

tions, in Morrison we have *that hedge, and that hill*. *Spazi di l da quella*, where *quella* refers to *siepe* and is therefore an important spatial marker, is elliptically rendered as *the space behind*.

The analysis of Morrison's version of *L'Infinito* evinces that the unfaithfulness to the original form inevitably brings about an unfaithfulness to its content. If to this one adds the fact that Morrison also distorts the crystalline style of Leopardi with his artificially archaizing Victorian diction, it can be concluded that his version, despite his claims of fidelity, is very close to Dryden's definition of imitation: that is, where the translator assumes the liberty, not only to vary from the words and sense, but to forsake them both as he sees occasion. As Lefevere points out, not unlike his prose counterpart, also the rhyming translator fights a losing battle against the limitations he imposes on himself.³⁹ In this particular version, the search for rhyming has caused a distortion in its basic communicative value. By superimposing an alien form on the original, the rhyming translator has ended up, to paraphrase McLuhan, by transmitting the medium rather than the content.

The problem of poetic form is partially eluded with the use of blank verse, a more cognate form of the original than rhyming pentameter. Blank verse translations are the great bulk of all the existing English translations of *L'Infinito*, whether in the traditional iambic pentameter of Townsend and Cliffe or in the freer form of Barricelli and Nichols. The predilection of so many translators for this form can be explained in two ways. On the one hand, the use of blank verse can facilitate a mimetic imitation of poetic imagination: blank verse, as Heath-Stubbs rightly sensed, is more functional than other forms in reproducing the progression of thought. On the other hand, blank verse can be used to attain an equivalent effect, precisely a *textual equivalence* (in Popović's definition, the equivalence of form and shape). A similarity in form and structure allows the translator to adhere more closely to the pillar symbols of *L'Infinito*, those symmetries and correspondences distributed throughout the poem with quasi-geometrical precision.

As Lefevere says, the advantages of blank verse over rhyme and the other forms in general are twofold: a greater accuracy and a higher degree of literariness.⁴⁰ A closer investigation, however, reveals that blank verse can be more restrictive than one might expect. Blank verse writers, Lefevere says, have (i) the obligation to adhere, as closely as possible, to the met-

rical scheme, whether traditional or self-imposed, and (ii) the no less strict obligation to try to escape from the deadening regularity which that same metrical system tends to impose on the poem as a whole. Even though some variations on the metrical scheme are allowed, these are limited in number and can be applied only a limited number of times, because otherwise they tend to reinforce what they are supposed to weaken.⁴¹ The analysis of the different blank verse translations of *L'Infinito* confirms Lefevere's claim. All these versions are definitely more exact than Morrison's version. Nonetheless, like Morrison's rhymed translation, they also contain a series of semantic distortions as a result of the requirements of form. Cliffe, for instance, introduces a filler in line 2, the adjective *green* attributed to *hedge*: an unjustified addition, except that this verbal trick allows him to create a perfect pentameter line, from both a syllabic and an accentual point of view. Cliffe is evidently aware of the pivotal function of symmetries in *L'Infinito*, because he uses *green* as a filler again in line 9, before the second term of the dyad *siepe / piante* (Amid the green leaves rustling). Variations caused by metrical requirements also affect the syntactic structure of the poem, specifically the opposition coordinate/subordinate clauses, respectively governed by the conjunctions *ma*, *ove*, *come*, *cos*, and *e*. In Cliffe's translation, two of the four subordinate clauses are introduced by the coordinating conjunction *and*: *ove per poco / il cor non si spaura* becomes *and as with terror is my heart overcast*; *Cos tra questa/immensità* becomes *And so in this/Immensity*. The insertion of the two coordinating conjunctions is certainly justified from a poetic point of view, because it provides the extra syllable needed and it is also in agreement with English syntax, which favors coordination over subordination. However, the presence of the coordinating *and* dulls the syntactic contrast coordinate/subordinate and eliminates what in the original is a pause in the *continuum* of thought. The use of *and* is also caused by Cliffe's attempt to artificially introduce antique wording with *overcast*. It would therefore be sufficient to restore the normal spelling of the adjective, *overcast* and to eliminate the conjunction *and* to have the same required number of syllables. Despite this and other minor flaws, the blank verse translation by Cliffe is overall more effective than all the translations so far analyzed, both in retaining the layout of pillar symbols and in imitating the progression of thought. This is basically true of the other blank verse translations as well, as an analysis of

their texts would prove.

If it can be theorized that blank verse is an effective instrument in conveying the structure and the dynamic tension of the original, conversely it can also be hypothesized that the less structured modes of rendition are detrimental. This is the case, for instance, with interpretation, according to its definition given by Lefevere. In interpretation, Lefevere says, the writer basically keeps the substance of the source text but changes its form. The theoretical advantage of interpretation over rhymed translation and blank verse, freeing the writer from any formal limitation, in the translation of *L'Infinito* becomes a liability. In fact, as we have repeatedly seen, in *L'Infinito* form is not only the poem's *involucrum*, or its supporting framework, but also its substance: the dissolution of the original form inevitably brings about the dissolution of its content. This proves to be true also for the three interpretations of *L'Infinito* here examined, although in different degrees.

The translations by Flores, Fowler, and Lowell cover different areas of the interpretative spectrum, ranging from quasi-fidelity (Flores) to almost total reinvention (Lowell), with Fowler's translation in an intermediate position. In Flores's version, there is no metrical or rhythmical correspondence to the original, but other correspondences are retained. By collating the structures of original and version, it can be seen that conformities prevail over discrepancies. Images develop more or less in parallel, enjambements are on the same lines (even though they emphasize different words), syntactic cruxes are located in similar positions, and finally also the various symmetries basically correspond. Where Flores's version diverges is mainly at the denotative level. Natural images, for instance, present all sorts of geological and botanical variations. In line 1, *colle* is rendered as *hidden knoll*, a *hillock* instead of a *hill* (not to mention the adjective *hidden* as a free addition); in line 2, *siepe* is rendered as *shrubbery*, a *bush* instead of a *hedge*; in line 9, *piante* is rendered as *greenery*, *verdure* instead of *trees*. In Leopardi, as mentioned before, idylls take form when a place permeated with old memories stirs particular sensations in the poet's mind. His definition bears a striking resemblance to that of Eliot's objective correlative: The only way of expressing emotion in the form of art is by finding an objective correlative, in other words, a set of objects, a situation, a chain of events which shall be the formula of that particular emotion. Now, what stirred Leopardi's poetic emotion

was a certain set of objects and no other: a hill and not a hillock, a hedge and not some shrubbery. Compared with the distortions in the rhymed and blank verse translations, these semantic shifts seem particularly unjustified because they are not dictated by requisites of rhyme and meter. The version, says Lefevere, strikes the reader as possessing a greater communicative value than the source text itself. The emphasis seems to lie in the shock value of words and images, rather than on a balanced whole : a description that perfectly fits Flores version.⁴² Even though in this translation there is no clear departure from the original pillar symbols, the semantic variations introduced here produce the same result: *colle* and *siepe* are part of the dyadic relationship subject/object: by altering the latter, the translator affects also the former.

In Fowler's version, the departure from the pillar symbols is more pronounced, and distortions occur both at the semantic and the structural levels. The first two and last two lines are revelatory in this respect. The first lines of Fowler's version read: They were always friends, this hill where no one comes/And this hedge here. Compared with the original, Fowler describes the images of nature from a slightly different angle. He removes the indirect object pronoun *mi*, crucial in establishing the connection object/subject, and replaces *ermo* with the oblique *where no one comes*. In the last two lines, however, Fowler retains the indirect object and gratuitously creates a new image with the adjective *pacific* : and it seems to me a gentle thing/To suffer shipwreck in this pacific ocean. Therefore, this version also fails to reproduce the symmetrical relationship of subject/object linking the first and the last lines.

Finally, Lowell's imitation is the translation that formally distances itself the most from the original, as even a simple cursory look at its structure would reveal. Using once again the symmetry subject/object as a paradigm, we can see that what is synthetically contained in the original in two lines is now distributed over six lines. The opening and the end of the poem are shaped as follows: That hill pushed off by itself was always dear/ to me and the hedges near/it...; It's sweet to destroy my mind/ and go down / and wreck in this sea. The relation subject/object is basically retained, but not the symmetry between the two indirect objects *mi*. Also, to save the rhyming couplet *dear/near*, Lowell disregards another case of symmetry, *questo colle* and *questa siepe*, rendered as *that hill* and *the hedge*.⁴³ The semantic and structural shifts are too

numerous to be listed here. However, this translation should not be judged by the same yardstick as used for the other translations. As Lowell states in the introduction to his book of *Imitations*, his translations are partly self-sufficient and separate from their sources and are not inspired by faithfulness or literalness: Boris Pasternak had said that the usual reliable translator gets the literal meaning but misses the tone, and that in poetry the tone is of course everything. I have been reckless with literal meaning, and labored hard to get the tone.⁴⁴ As a precaution against any possible criticism, Lowell sets the parameters according to which his versions should be viewed, by saying: I have been almost as free as the authors themselves finding ways to make them ring right for me.⁴⁵ An analysis aimed at determining how effectively the original structure is carried over into English is clearly inapplicable here, since Lowell programmatically sets himself to restructure the source poem. In creating his own tone, Lowell abandons the rhythmic and metric framework of the original, built on free hendecasyllables, and constructs a new framework based on free verse. He creates a new set of rhymes, assonances, symmetries, and syntactic nexuses, in a natural style that reflects the musicality of modern language. In his imitation, all these elements have become the new pillar symbols, and the original images are compressed or expanded to fit the new structure.⁴⁶ In this light, one can explain the redundancy by which Lowell renders the series of adjectives *sovrumani*, *profondissima*, and *interminati* : When I would sit there lost in deliberation, / I reasoned most on interminable spaces / beyond all hills, on their antediluvian resignation / and silence that passes beyond's man's possibility. Leaving aside the questionable semantic value of the newly created concept antediluvian resignation, one cannot fail to notice the musicality inherent in the passage and its carefully built net of rhymes and assonances.

A certain amount of compensation is unavoidable in any translation, as even the most fervent literalists, such as the Romantics, admit.⁴⁷ As proven here, however, in imitation compensation techniques inevitably lead to overcompensation. The danger inherent in this method is that by additions of new words and images, the character of the original author progressively disappears. This danger was already perceived by Dryden, who in his comparison of the imitations of Ovid and Virgil stated:

... not only the thoughts, but the style and

versification of Virgil and Ovid are very different: yet I see, even in our best poets, who have translated some parts of them, that they have confounded their several talents; and, by endeavouring only at the sweetness and harmony of numbers, have made them both so much alike, that, if I did not know the originals, I should never be able to judge by the copies which was Virgil, and which was Ovid ... In such translators I can easily distinguish the hand which performed the work, but I cannot distinguish their poet from another. Suppose two authors are equally sweet, yet there is a great distinction to be made in sweetness, as in that of sugar and that of honey.⁴⁸

The uniformity of rendition is easily verifiable in Lowell's *Imitations*, a selection of poems from different authors and periods, ranging from Homer to Pasternak. In one instance, for example, Lowell uses the same image for two different poets, Leopardi and Montale. The opening of Lowell's *Infinite* is 'That hill pushed off by itself. This is a quite incomprehensible image, unless one examines it in parallel to a similar image in Montale's *Dora Markus*: 'Fu dove il ponte di legno/ mette a Porto Corsini sul mare alto,' which is rendered by Lowell as 'It was a plank pier/ pushed from Porto Corsini into the open sea. In Lowell's poetic idiolect, one can infer, something pushed is something jutting or protruding. The hill, being of natural formation, is pushed off by itself, whereas the plank pier, being manmade, is simply pushed. What matters here is not so much the strangeness of the concept, but the fact that the past participle pushed creates an image used in two totally different contexts, regardless of what could be the style or lexicon of the original authors.

Allen Tate has likened Lowell's book of *Imitations* to Pope's translation of Homer: 'Of [Lowell's] passage from Homer ... one may say what Bentley said to Alexander Pope: A pretty poem, Mr. Pope, but it is not Homer. This is true of Lowell, but it is irrelevant. What is wrong with Lowell's fragment of Homer is something quite different. It is not good Lowell.'⁴⁹ Likewise, one may say of this imitation of *L'Infinito* that it is not Leopardi, and furthermore that it is not good Lowell. The problem with his imitation is not the liberties he takes with Leopardi's original, but the fact that he stops halfway. The contrivance of certain images, like that of

the silence that passes / beyond man's possibility, suggest in fact that his imitation is not free from the bonds of its source. I have been almost as free as the authors themselves, Lowell says. And perhaps the key to this unsatisfactory translation lies in that almost. Although Lowell questions the status of the original by declaring himself more a creator than a re-creator, the relationship of dependency has not been completely reversed.

Imitation, like all the previous forms analyzed, fails to provide an adequate rendition of *L'Infinito*. To quote Lefevere once again, the reasons why most translations, versions, and imitations are unsatisfactory renderings of the source text is simply this: they all concentrate exclusively on one aspect of that source text only, rather than its totality.⁵⁰ As we have repeatedly seen, however, to render the totality of *L'Infinito* is practically impossible. The translator of *L'Infinito* must choose an approach between the two extremes theorized by Schleiermacher: either he moves the reader toward the writer or he moves the writer toward the reader. The two extremes correspond to literal translation and imitation, respectively. The first option is represented here by Smith's prose version, which exhibits a certain elegance but serves mainly as a bridge to the original; the second option is that of imitation, represented here by Lowell's version, which attempts to naturalize and modernize Leopardi's poem. In between are the rhymed translation by Morrison and the various blank verse versions by Cliffe and many others, which attempt to reach a balance of form and content. Each one of these translations, as we have seen, is both loyal and disloyal to the original, in the sense that each one retains certain pillar symbols and fails to reproduce others. The concentration on a particular pillar symbol can be a result of the translator's conscious desire to highlight certain aspects of the poem; or it can be a consequence of his failure (either programmatic or fortuitous) to complete one or more of the eight stages identified by Bly. Smith, for instance, certainly reached stage three, in which the literal version is rephrased according to the genius of the target language, but did not go beyond that. Morrison never completed stage four, in which the poem is rendered according to the spoken language. Fowler never went through stage seven, in which unjustified deviations or misappropriations on behalf of the translator are corrected.

The lack of correspondence between translation and original, as we have seen, reveals itself in various forms of distortion: rhythmic, phonetic, syntactic, semantic,

and stylistic. And yet, behind all the possible distortions, lies, to use Popovič's definition, the invariant core of *L'Infinito*.⁵¹ In spite of all possible shortcomings, none of these translations can be rejected, because each of them contains a key to the core of the text. Also, for all of these translations, a comment made by Sell's could be used, based on the comparative analysis of three English translations of Lorca's *Romancero Gitano*:

In the study of the elements analyzed, it is clear that for one translation problem several solutions are possible and that the overall solutions offered by each translator can be considered a creation which, in a sense, reproduces the original and is at the same time a new work.⁵²

The house of fiction, as Henry James said, has not one window, but a million pierced, pierceable. Each translation of *L'Infinito* is a window opened by each translator, to which the reader can go and look at the core of the original from a particular angle. And given the tantalizing difficulty of this idyll, many new windows will be opened.

Notes

¹ Legend: enjambement; * lines containing prolepsis or inverted order; **bold face**, connectives. The notation system is adapted from Blanca Maria de las Nieves Mu iz Mu iz, *Tradurre L'Infinito* (intorno ad alcune versioni spagnole dei *Canti* leopardiani), in *La Corrispondenza Imperfetta*, ed. Anna Dolfi and Adriana Mitescu (Roma: Bulzoni Editore, 1990).

² George Steiner, *After Babel* (New York and London: Oxford University Press, 1975).

³M. H. Abrams, *Structure and Style in the Greater Romantic Lyric*, in: Harold Bloom, ed. *Romanticism and Consciousness* (New York: Norton, 1970) 201–202, quoted in Margaret Brose, *Leopardi and the Romantic Sublime*, in *Poetics Today* vol. 4, 1, 1983, 49.

⁴ Circa le sensazioni che piacciono pel solo indefinito puoi vedere il mio idillio sull'Infinito, e richiamar l'idea di una campagna arditamente declive in guisa che la vista in certa lontananza non arrivi alla valle; e quella di un filare d'alberi, la cui fine si perda di vista, o per lunghezza del filare, o perch'esso sia pure posto in declivio, ec. ec. ec. Una fabbrica una torre ecc. veduta in modo ch'ella paia innalzarsi sola sopra l'orizzonte, e

questo non si veda, produce un contrasto efficacissimo e sublimissimo fra l'infinito e l'indefinito, ec. ecc. ecc. *Zibaldone, 1429–1431* [1^a agosto 1821], trans. Renato Poggioli, in *The Poem Itself*, ed. Stanley Burnshaw (New York: Holt, Rinehart, Winston, 1960), 276.

⁵Zibaldone, I: 135–137, April 1820, quoted in Brose, op. cit., 54.

⁶ For Locke, Brose points out, the idea of infinity is actually derived from sensation: the mind extrapolates from empirical experience the sensation of space, duration, and number, and then reconceptualizes these in terms of an *endless* repetition. John Locke, *An essay concerning human understanding*, ed. Peter H. Nidditch (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1975), II, 17, quoted in Brose, 56.

⁷As Brose points out, the contrastive structure of *L'Infinito* involves two other kinds of metalepsis, a substitution of the visual field with the imaginative field, and of the temporal field with the spatial field. Brose, op. cit., p. 59. Cf. also Poggioli, who in these lines sees a shift from the intuition of infinity to that of eternity. Poggioli, op. cit., 277.

⁸Another pattern of phonetic chiasmus is the acrostic alliteration in *vento* and *eterno*. The chiasmic reversal *voov* can be seen in *voce* and *vo* comparando, as opposed to *mi sovvien*. Brose, op. cit., 65–66.

⁹Example of accents on second and sixth syllables: *Le donne, i cavalier, l'arme, gli amori...* (L. Ariosto); accents on fourth and eighth syllables: *Le cortesie, le audaci imprese io canto...* (L. Ariosto); accents on fourth and seventh syllables: *E un incalzar di cavalli accorrenti...* (U. Foscolo).

¹⁰As Mandelbaum remarks in reference to *Divine Comedy*'s tercets, the hendecasyllable often has ... an internal balancing needle. Around that needle, when the obligatory stress on the tenth syllable is complemented by an initial iamb and consequent stress on the second syllable, we can generate not only homeopodic (or superimposed) symmetry, but antipodic (mirror) symmetry... Allen Mandelbaum, *Introduction to Dante's Inferno* (Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1980), xxi. Cf. also Giuseppe Sansone, *La struttura ritmica dell'Infinito*, *Forum Italicum* 4, 331–337.

¹¹Brose, op. cit., 67.

¹²Cf. for instance Mario Fubini in *Metrica e Poesia* (Milano: Feltrinelli, 1962), 66–69.

¹³As Francesco Flora points out, Leopardi's lexicon is, from a literary point of view, very ordinary, formed almost solely of trite words and expressions from academic language and Arcadia. In Leopardi's poetic lan-

guage ... il fato acerbo o duro; la vita il viver, anzi il viver mio; il tempo l'et, l'etade, la stagion... In questa lingua che pare fissata una volta per sempre da Francesco Petrarca, e ripresa da Metastasio, l'anima l'alma; il cuore quasi sempre cor... Ebbene, proprio con queste parole, nei loro giri più letterariamente tradizionali, e che a prenderli staccati paiono consunti e perfino ridicoli, proprio con queste voci sollevate in una musica che le fa risuonare sotto un nuovo arco, ove pare che siano dette per la prima volta, Giacomo Leopardi ha creato i suoi più originali incanti. Quel vieto frasario il poeta rinnova con un semplice tocco e da letterario lo trasforma in poetico. Tutta l'Arcadia si riscatta in poesia. Giacomo Leopardi, *Canti, con una scelta di prose*, ed. Francesco Flora (Milano: Mondadori, 1963), 7–8.

¹⁴H.F. Brown, *MacMillan's magazine*, vol. LVI, May–October, no. 798, 1887, pp. 88–105. By Brown, see also *S.A. Symonds: A Biography* (1903). Quoted in G. Singh, *Leopardi e l'Inghilterra* (Firenze: Le Monnier, 1968), 68–69.

¹⁵The ideal translator of Leopardi, the review suggests, to be the most successful should first imbue his mind with the works of three English poets: Cowper, Wordsworth and Shelley. *Athenaeum*, 3838, May 1901, quoted in G. Singh, op. cit., 94–95.

¹⁶Introduced in the XVI century by H.H. Surrey in his translation of books II and IV of Virgil's *Aeneid*, blank verse was used in theater for the first time by Th. Norton and Th. Sackville in *Gorboduc* (1560). Perfected by Marlowe, blank verse will become the reference point in the complex evolution of Elizabethan theater, the meter of English dramatic poetry from Shakespeare's time onward. It will be as important in epic poetry, from Milton to Keats and Tennyson.

¹⁷Lascelles Abercrombie, *Principles of English Prosody* (1923), quoted in G. Singh, op. cit., 105.

¹⁸Some classical scholars, for example, notably Professors J.P. Postgate and A.E. Housman, apparently have convinced themselves that for certain Latin or Greek meters there are analogous optimum English meters into which any translation should be made. Thus if the original is in hexameters, the translation should be in blank verse; if in elegiac couplets, in pentameter couplets; and so forth. Postgate invokes mathematics in his consideration of poetic forms, and extends his arithmetic, by unimpeccable logic, to the number of lines permissible in a translation of a given Latin original. W. Frost, op. cit., 20. Cf. Postgate, *Translation and Translations* (Bell, 1922), 65 ff., 74, 83, 91 f.

The line is so obvious and so basic an organizing

agent in poetry generally that upon some translators it has exerted an irrational, almost hypnotic influence, causing the production of those line-for-line versions which still occasionally appear. W. Frost, op. cit., 49.

¹⁹Figuerola, *Problems in translation*, 96.

²⁰Cf. Giuseppe Sansone, *Traduzione ritmica e traduzione metrica*, in *la Traduzione del testo Poetico*, F. Buffoni ed., 18.

²¹Mounin, op. cit., 142–144.

²²Robert Lowell, *Imitations* (New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 1965, 4th ed.), 25.; George R. Kay, ed. *The Penguin Book of Italian Verse* (Harmondsworth 1958, 1962). 272.

²³Buffoni then cites as an example of respectful translation this version by Brose: Always dear to me was this solitary hill,/ And this hedge, which from so great a part / Of the farthest horizon excludes the gaze./ But sitting and gazing, boundless / Spaces beyond that, and superhuman / Silences, and profoundest quiet / I in my mind create. This translation is in a way in contradiction to his prescriptions: while it is true that this version is more respectful of the original than Lowell's, it is also true that it adheres to the original word order even more closely than Kay's. F. Buffoni, *Leopardi in lingua inglese come paradigma della simbolicità del compito di un poeta traduttore*, in *La Traduzione del Testo Poetico*, op. cit., 109, 111.

²⁴Cf. Buffoni, 107.

²⁵Cf. Muir, 131.

²⁶William Ellery Leonard, preface to his translation of *Lucretius* (Dutton, 1921), xi, quoted in W. Frost, *Dryden and the Art of Translation* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1955), 19.

²⁷Cf. W. Frost, op. cit., 18–19.

²⁸Cf. Max Bense, in *Augenblick*, n. 1/58. An application of the semantical informative function of translation can be found in Longfellow's rendition of the *Divina Commedia*. The only merit my book has is that it is exactly what Dante says, and not what the translator imagines he might have said if he had been an Englishman. Henry Wadsworth Longfellow, quoted in William J. De Sua, *Dante into English* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1964), 65.

²⁹A. Lefevere, *Translating Poetry*, op. cit., 42.

³⁰Lefevere, op. cit., 47.

³¹*Literary Essays of Ezra Pound*, op. cit., 25.

³²*The Translation of Poetry*, op. cit., 31.

³³The concept of *écriture d'ombres* and of the missing word in modern literature is discussed in G. Steiner, *After Babel*, op. cit., 183.

³⁴Cf. Stauffer's comment on structure in Arnold's poem *Isolation*. D. Stauffer, *The Nature of Poetry*, op. cit., 233.

³⁵John Heath-Stubbs, *Poems of Giacomo Leopardi* (1946), and Irigo Jones and J. Heath-Stubbs, *Giacomo Leopardi: Selected Prose and Poetry*, (1966), quoted in G. Singh, *Leopardi e l'Inghilterra*, op. cit., 141.

³⁶Lefevere, 49.

³⁷Lefevere, 51.

³⁸Lefevere, 52—54.

³⁹Lefevere, 61.

⁴⁰Lefevere, op. cit., 76. The superiority of blank verse over rhyme as a more accurate instrument of reproduction was emphasized by Longfellow. In discussing his translation of Dante's *Divine Comedy*, he said: ... while making it rhythmic, I have endeavoured to make it also as literal as a prose translation... In translating Dante, something must be relinquished. Shall it be the beautiful rhyme that blossoms all along the line like a honeysuckle on the hedge? It must be, in order to retain something more precious than rhyme, namely, fidelity, truth, the life of the hedge itself... Henry Wadsworth Longfellow, quoted in William J. De Sua, *Dante into English* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1964), 65.

⁴¹Lefevere, op. cit., 61.

⁴²Lefevere, op. cit., 76.

⁴³Cf. Buffoni, op. cit., 109.

⁴⁴Robert Lowell, *Imitations* (New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 1965, 4th ed.), xi.

⁴⁵Lowell, op. cit., xiii.

⁴⁶As to structure, various features of the source text are compressed, others expanded. Lefevere, op. cit., 78.

⁴⁷Wordsworth, writing to the editors of the *Philological Museum* about a specimen of his translations from the *Aeneid*, said, Having been displeased in modern translations with the addition of incongruous matter, I began to translate with a resolve to keep clear of that fault, by adding nothing; but I became aware that a spirited translation can scarcely be accomplished in the English language without admitting a principle of compensation. Quoted in C. Day-Lewis, *On Translating Poetry*, 16.

⁴⁸Dryden, preface to *Sylvae: Or, the Second Part of Poetical Miscellanies* (1685), in *Theories of Translation*, op. cit., 24.

⁴⁹*The Translation of Poetry*, op. cit., 5.

⁵⁰Lefevere, 99.

⁵¹It is an established fact in Translation Studies that if a dozen translators tackle the same poem, they will

produce a dozen different versions. And yet somewhere in those dozen versions there will be what Popovi calls the invariant core of the original poem. This invariant core, he claims, is represented by stable, basic and constant semantic elements in the text, whose existence can be proved by experimental semantic condensation. Transformations, or variants, are those changes which do not modify the core of meaning but influence the expressive form. In short, the invariant can be defined as that which exists in common between all existing translations of a single work. Bassnett-McGuire, op. cit., 26—27.

⁵²Nivea E. Aponte Sell's, *Problemas de la Traducción Poética Ilustrados por Tres Traducciones del Romance Sonmbulo*, trans. Kathleen Kelly, in *Problems in Translation*, 166—168.

Appendix

The Infinite

This lonely hill to me was ever dear,

This hedge, which shuts from view so large a part

Of the remote horizon. As I sit
And gaze, absorbed, I in my thought conceive
The boundless spaces that beyond it range,
The silence supernatural, and rest
Profound; and for a moment I am calm.
And as I listen to the wind, that through
These trees is murmuring, its plaintive voice
I with that infinite compare;
And things eternal I recall, and all
The seasons dead, and this, that round me lives,
And utters its complaint. Thus wandering
My thought in this immensity is drowned;
And sweet to me is shipwreck on this sea.

Frederick Townsend, 1887

This lonely knoll was ever dear to me
and this hedgerow that hides from view
so large a part of the remote horizon.
But as I sit and gaze my thought conceives
interminable spaces lying beyond
and supernatural silences
and profoundest calm, until my heart
almost becomes dismayed. And as I hear
the wind come rustling through these leaves,
I find myself comparing to this voice
that infinite silence: and I recall eternity

and all the ages that are dead
and the living present and its sounds. And so
in this immensity my thought is drowned:
and in this sea is foundering sweet to me.

Gian Piero Barricelli, 1986

The Infinite

I always did value this lonely hill,
And this hedgerow also, where so wide a stretch
Of the extreme horizon s out of sight.
But sitting here and gazing, I find that endless
Spaces beyond that hedge, and more-than-human
Silences, and the deepest peace and quiet
Are fashioned in my thought; so much that almost
My heart fills up with fear. And as I hear
The wind rustle among the leaves, I set
That infinite silence up against this voice,
Comparing them; and I recall the eternal,
And the dead seasons, and the present one
Alive, and all the sound of it. And so
In this immensity my thought is drowned:
And I enjoy my sinking in this sea.

J.G. Nichols, 1994

The Infinite

They were always friends, this hill where no one
comes
And this hedge here, that from so large a part
Of the ultimate horizon shuts out the eye.
Sitting in contemplation, I form unbounded
Distances on the other side, silences
Past man, and deepest calm. Then my heart comes
Close to taking fright; and, as the breeze
Rustles among the leaves, I keep comparing
That infinite silence to this small voice: recall
Eternity, and the seasons that are gone,
And the living present one, the sound of it.
And so my thought founders, lost in this
Immensity; and it seems to me a gentle thing
To suffer shipwreck in this pacific ocean.

Alastair Fowler, 1987

The Infinite

This lonely hill has always been so dear

To me, and dear the hedge which hides away
The reaches of the sky. But sitting here
And wondering, I fashion in my mind
The endless spaces far beyond, the more
Than human silences, and deepest peace,
So that the heart is on the edge of fear.
And when I hear the wind come blowing through
The trees, I pit its voice against that boundless
Silence and summon up eternity
And the dead seasons, and the present one,
Alive with all its sound. And thus it is
In this immensity my thought is drowned:
And sweet to me the foundering in this sea.

O. Mark Casale, 1984

The Infinite

Dear to me always was this lonely hill,
And this hedge that excludes so large a part
Of the ultimate horizon from my view.
But as I sit and gaze, my thought conceives
Interminable vastnesses of space
Beyond it, and unearthly silences,
And profoundest calm; whereat my heart almost
Becomes dismayed. And as I hear the wind
Blustering through these branches, I find myself
Comparing with this sound that infinite silence;
And then I call to mind eternity,
And the ages that are dead, and this that now
Is living, and the noise of it. And so
In this immensity my thought sinks drowned:
And sweet it seems to shipwreck in this sea.

R.C. Trevelyan, 1941

The Infinite

This lonely hill was always dear to me,
And this hedgerow, that hides so large a part
Of the far sky-line from my view. Sitting and gazing,
I fashion in my mind what lie beyond
Unearthly silences, and endless space,
And very deepest quiet; then for a while
The heart is not afraid. And when I hear
The wind come blustering among the trees
I set that voice against this infinite silence:
And then I call to mind Eternity,
The ages that are dead, and the living present

And all the noise of it. And thus it is
In that immensity my thought is drowned:
And sweet to me the foundering in that sea.

John Heath-Stubbs, 1966

The Infinite

That hill pushed off by itself was always dear
to me and the hedges near
it that cut away so much of the final horizon.
When I would sit there lost in deliberation,
I reasoned most on the interminable spaces
beyond all hills, on their antediluvian resignation
and silence that passes
beyond man's possibility.
Here for a while my heart is quiet inside me;
and when the wind lifts roughing through the trees,
I set about comparing my silence to those voices,
and I think about the eternal, the dead seasons,
things here at hand and alive,
and all their reasons and choices.
It's sweet to destroy my mind
and go down
and wreck in this sea where I drown.

Robert Lowell, 1958

The Infinite

This hidden knoll has been always dear to me,
And this shrubbery, that keeps obscure
So much of the ultimate horizon.
But sitting now and gazing, illimitable
Spaces yonder, and superhuman
Silences, and profoundest quiet
Come to mind; where still the heart
Knows scarcely fear. And listening to the wind
Rustling in this greenery, to
That infinite silence I compare
This voice: and I ponder the eternal,
And the dead seasons, and the present
And living, and its sound. Thus in this immensity
My meditations drown:
And it is sweet to lose myself in this sea.

Kate Flores, 1966.

The Infinite

Dear ever to my heart that lonely hill
Hath been, that hedge, too, which extending wide
The view of farthest horizon doth hide.
Here as I sit and muse, my thoughts at will

Do summon scenes of boundless space behind,
Of silence passing human ken, and rest
Unbroke, unfathomed, whereat the breast
In awe doth well-nigh sink! And when the wind

I hear surge through the rustling leaves that sway,
I aye compare its whispers with that all
Pervading silence deep, and I recall
Eternity, and ages passed away!

The present lives, and all its stress with me,
Howe'er. Thus in the boundless Infinite
My fancy sinks, like drowning man from sight
How sweet to suffer wreck on such a sea!

J.M. Morrison, 1900

The Infinite

I always loved this solitary hill
And this green hedge that hides on every side
The last and dim horizon from our view.
But as I sit and gaze, a never-ending
Space far beyond it and unearthly silence
And deepest quiet to my thought I picture,
And as with terror is my heart overcast
With wondrous awe. And while I hear the wind
Amid the green leaves rustling, I compare
That silence infinite unto this sound,
And to my mind eternity occurs,
And all the vanished ages, and the present
Whose sound doth meet mine ear. And so in this
Immensity my thought is drifted on,
And to be wrecked on such a sea is sweet.

Francis Henry Cliffe, 1903.

The Infinite

Always dear to me was this lonely hill and this hedge that from so great a space the horizon shuts off my sight. But sitting and gazing I fashion in my thought the interminable spaces there beyond the hedge and the supernal silences and the profound quietude; wherein my heart becomes almost bewildered. And as I hear the wind sounding in these trees, I go comparing that infinite silence with this voice of the wind; and I become aware of the eternity of time and the extinct ages and the age present and living and the sound of it. Thus in this immensity my thought is drowned: and sweet to me is shipwreck in such a sea.

Fletcher Smith, 1939

The Infinite

It was always dear to me, this solitary hill, and this hedge which shuts off the gaze from so large a part of the uttermost horizon. But sitting and looking out, in thought I fashion for myself endless spaces beyond, more-than-human silences, and deepest quiet; where the heart is all but terrified. And as I hear the wind rustling among these plants, I go on and compare this voice to that infinite silence: and I recall the eternal, and the dead seasons, and the present, living one and her sound. So in this immensity my thoughts drown: and shipwreck is sweet to me in this sea.

George R. Kay

[(1) Always dear to me was this solitary hill, (2) And this hedge, which from so great a part (3) Of the farthest horizon excludes the gaze. (4) But sitting and gazing, boundless (5) Spaces beyond that, and superhuman (6) Silences, and profoundest quiet (7) I in my imagine (create); wherefore (8) The heart is almost filled with fear. And as (9) I hear the wind rustle through these plants, that (10) Infinite silence to this voice (11) I go on comparing: and I recall to mind the eternal, (12) And the dead seasons, and the present (13) And living one, and the sound of it. So in this (14) Immensity my thought is drowned: (15) And the shipwreck is sweet to me in this sea.]

Margaret Brose